Mr. Sudhir Mantena,
Director of Products,
Cleartrip

SOLVING CUSTOMER PROBLEMS

Cleartrip builds simple to use yet powerful tools for customers to plan their travels

Aditya Madanapalle
aditya@digit.in

What approaches does Cleartrip take to differentiate itself from the competition?

Mantena: We have clearly focused on solving the customer's problem and not necessarily throwing money at it. The product, the product design and the analytics teams spend an enormous amount of time looking at the consumer behavior. We measure hundreds of different attributes, and identify problem statements. In domestic air, we are focusing on how the consumer searches, how many times do they search, how frequently do they have to come back again to check the price and how many days does it take for them to make a decision. People are really anxious before making that decision. The cost of making a wrong decision is high. Say a customer comes and searches for Bengaluru to Delhi. They will come to the site multiple times every day searching for flights, and check if the fares are changing or not changing. In order to save the customer from coming back so many times and searching repeatedly, we built something called "Fare Alerts". If you go set a Fare Alert for a particular destination and a travel date, Cleartrip automatically tracks the fares on your behalf. Immediately after the fare has dropped, let's say in case an airline announces a flash sale, Cleartrip will notify you. Obviously, there will be a limited inventory with reduced fare, if somebody is serious they can go ahead and book. Second pressure point is just before the fare is about to increase. Cleartrip as a system knows when the fare is about to increase. Just before it is about to increase, Cleartrip will notify the customers and they can go ahead and make a booking. Another behavior that we noticed among a lot of domestic travelers is, let's say, again you are going from Bengaluru to Delhi, and you have a choice of either going on Friday after office, or Saturday early in the morning. After office is over on Friday, I will look for a flight which departs after 8PM or 9PM, so that I can finish my office and head to the airport and then catch the flight. Airlines have also figured this out, and usually for Friday evening, the fares more expensive, because everybody has the same preference. Now imagine a round trip scenario where you have flexibility on the return journey as well. It becomes very complicated as you start adding these variables. What we recently introduced is something called "Date Tabs". On the search results page, you see multiple Date Tabs. There is a tab for the previous date, two days previous, one day later and two days later also. You can apply filters for a day, and automatically the cheapest fare is visible on the tab itself. Now you can have multiple dates you can compare on the tab, without having to take notes on a piece of paper, or open multiple browser tabs. It becomes very easy for the consumer to compare these fares.

Do you use AI in any of your products?

Mantena: The terminology is often interchangeably used without necessarily understanding what it means, at Cleartrip we use more of machine learning not so much of AI yet. Machine learning is used to solve a lot of consumer problems. These are problems that I don't think that anybody in the global OTA space has solved yet. Cleartrip is trying to tackle them. I would not claim that we have solved the problem, but to answer your question, yes we are using a lot of machine learning. First problem is when to book. If you are going from Bengaluru to London, and you have April or May as the time frame. Depending on when I start searching, the fares may be either low or high. But when is the best time to book? In international flights we see a lot of fare fluctuation. It is just the nature of international flights. So we are using a lot of data analytics and machine learning to figure out when is the best time to book. Should you wait for three or seven more days, or should you book now, because our model suggests that there is no way that the fares are going to fall. This is an extremely hard problem to solve, but we are taking a crack at it. The second problem is when is the best time to fly. It requires a good amount of machine learning and data analytics to predict that. If you were interested in the second week of May, but actually if you consider fourth week of May, you may get better fares. We are working on some of those problems right now.